

CONCEPTION



» pages 26–45

The first step in your pregnancy journey, this chapter looks at the incredible chain of events that lead to conception, with detailed explanations of how your monthly cycle prepares your body for pregnancy, and on how pregnancy is established with the implantation of the tiny embryo. From optimizing fertility to the early signs of pregnancy, this chapter helps you prepare for and navigate these first important weeks.

NUTRITION, EXERCISE, AND WELL-BEING



» pages 46–75

Pregnancy comes with a bewildering array of advice on what you should and shouldn't do to keep you and your baby healthy. This chapter provides clear-cut guidelines on which foods to avoid, and explains how healthy eating can optimize your baby's early development. Sensible exercise advice and relaxation techniques help you deal with common pregnancy concerns, and develop stamina and focus for labor.

PRENATAL CARE



» pages 76–103

The type of care you receive is a primary concern in pregnancy. This chapter details the options for prenatal care and who you can expect to take care of you. It also prompts you to think about where you want to give birth, who you would like to be with you, and what type of birth you would prefer. A section on all the tests and ultrasounds you will be offered in pregnancy helps you to understand why these are done and how they can benefit you and your baby.

ALL ABOUT YOU



» pages 104–147

The changes to your body in pregnancy impact many aspects of life, from your relationship with your partner to your ability to stay comfortable and sleep, to making travel arrangements. In addition to these practical matters, this chapter also explores the many physical and emotional changes pregnancy brings, and looks at some of the common complaints and complications of pregnancy and how to manage them.

YOUR GROWING BABY



» pages 148–171

Nothing is more fascinating in pregnancy than the incredible development of your baby in the uterus. This chapter documents each step of your baby's progress, showing how, within a matter of weeks, your baby develops from a tiny bundle of cells to a recognizably human fetus. In addition to her external growth and features, we look at how your baby's vital organs develop and at the unique genetic inheritance your baby holds.

PRACTICAL PREPARATIONS



» pages 172–195

From maternity and nursing bras, support belts, and pregnancy jeans, through to nursing pillows, strollers, cribs, and sleep suits, there's a whole host of items you will need for your pregnancy and your baby when he arrives. This chapter helps you to make practical choices, gives tips on what to buy when, and ensures that you have all you need to get you through pregnancy and the early weeks and months with your new baby.

LABOR AND BIRTH



» pages 196–239

A dedicated chapter on labor and birth guides you through each stage of labor, showing you how to recognize when labor is really underway and how to chart its progress. Guidance on pain-relief options will help you consider which techniques and medications you might prefer to use in labor. And you can find out what happens right after the birth: how your baby is taken care of, how you might feel, and how to kick-start the bonding process.

THE POSTPARTUM PERIOD



» pages 240–301

During pregnancy, you will want to think ahead to life with your new baby. This chapter allows you to do just that, providing a glimpse into what you can expect, and preparing you for the everyday care of your baby. You can read up on essential areas such as feeding, washing, dressing, comforting, transporting your baby, and dealing with first illnesses. You'll also find advice and tips on how to give yourself time to heal and recover gently after the birth.

SPECIAL SITUATIONS



» pages 302–333

Sometimes pregnancy brings up painful and unexpected situations, whether the actual loss of the pregnancy, a baby that arrives too early and needs special care, or a newborn who has a particular medical concern or long-term condition. This chapter looks at some of the difficult and challenging scenarios families can face and offers advice, information, and guidance to help families understand, come to terms with, and cope with these situations.